
Contents

1	Day 1. Classic binomial and multinomial identities	1
2	Day 2. Stars, bars and Gauss summation trick	5
3	Day 3. Recurrence relations	9
4	Day 4. More recurrence equations	12
5	Day 5. Binomial coefficients and recurrence relations recap	15
6	Yet to discover	15

1 Day 1. Classic binomial and multinomial identities

Planned entrance quiz :)

1. How many ways are to order 6 persons in a queue?
2. The box contains 50 balls numbered from 1 to 50. We draw 6 balls without replacement and write down the resulting sequence of numbers. How many different sequences are possible?
3. I have 5 yellow books and 7 red books. I want to place them on my bookshelf and I would like to place yellow books to the left of red books. How many book orders are possible?

Definition 1.1. Factorial of n , denoted by $n!$, is the number of ways to put n distinct objects in a queue.

Definition 1.2. Binomial coefficient $\binom{n}{k}$ is the number of ways to select k distinct objects from n distinct objects.

Definition 1.3. For $n = a + b + c$ the multinomial coefficient $\binom{n}{a,b,c}$ is the number of ways to split n distinct objects into different boxes, where the first box contains a objects, the second box contains b objects, the third box contains c objects.

One may create multinomial coefficient for any number of boxes :)

Exercise 1.1. Is $\binom{n}{k}$ equal to $\binom{n}{n-k}$?

Is $\binom{n}{k}$ equal to $\binom{n}{k, n-k}$?

Exercise 1.2. Write the product

$$\binom{100}{20} \cdot \binom{80}{50} \cdot \binom{30}{10}$$

as one multinomial coefficient.

Exercise 1.3. Write

$$\binom{n}{a, b, c, d}$$

using binomial coefficients.

Write

$$\binom{n}{a, b, c, d}$$

using factorials of n , a , b , c and d .



Idea 1. Solution strategies for combinatorial identities:

1. Double counting or story proof.
2. Visual identity (rare gem!).
3. Evaluation of a polynomial at a special point. Differentiation, integration.
4. Combine old identities into new.
5. Guess the answer and verify by induction.
6. Dark art!

Pascal's triangle and rule

Exercise 1.4. Recall the Pascal arithmetic triangle. Draw two versions: triangular and rectangular.

Exercise 1.5. Pascal's rule. Simplify

$$\binom{n}{k} + \binom{n}{k+1}.$$
$$\binom{n}{a-1, b, c} + \binom{n}{a, b-1, c} + \binom{n}{a, b, c-1}.$$
$$\binom{n}{a-1, b, c, d} + \binom{n}{a, b-1, c, d} + \binom{n}{a, b, c-1, d} + \binom{n}{a, b, c, d-1}.$$

Exercise 1.6. Simplify

$$\binom{n}{0} + \binom{n}{1} + \binom{n}{2} + \cdots + \binom{n}{n}.$$

Recall the Pascal's rule and simplify

$$\binom{2n}{0} + \binom{2n}{2} + \binom{2n}{4} + \cdots + \binom{2n}{2n}.$$

Simplify

$$\binom{2n-1}{0} + \binom{2n-1}{2} + \binom{2n-1}{4} + \cdots + \binom{2n-1}{2n-2}.$$

Exercise 1.7. Simplify

$$\sum_{a+b+c=2026} \binom{2026}{a, b, c}.$$
$$\sum_{a+b+c+d=2027} \binom{2027}{a, b, c, d}.$$
$$\sum_{a+b+c=100} \binom{100}{a} \cdot \binom{100-a}{b}.$$
$$\sum_{a+b \leq n} \binom{n}{a} \cdot \binom{n-a}{b}.$$

Here a , b and c are assumed non-negative integers.

Hockey-stick identity

Exercise 1.8. Hockey-stick identity , Christmas stocking identity, boomerang identity.
Simplify

$$\sum_{n=a}^b \binom{n}{a}.$$

$$1 + 2 + 3 + \cdots + n.$$

$$1 \cdot 2 + 2 \cdot 3 + 3 \cdot 4 + \cdots + n \cdot (n + 1).$$

$$1 \cdot 2 \cdot 3 + 2 \cdot 3 \cdot 4 + 3 \cdot 4 \cdot 5 + \cdots + n \cdot (n + 1) \cdot (n + 2).$$

Exercise 1.9. Obtain closed form expressions for:

$$1^2 + 2^2 + \cdots + n^2,$$

$$1^3 + 2^3 + \cdots + n^3,$$

$$1^4 + 2^4 + \cdots + n^4.$$

Exercise 1.10. Hockey-sticks plus idea from linear algebra!

a) Decompose $n^2 + 2n + 5$ using $\binom{n}{0}$, $\binom{n}{1}$, $\binom{n}{2}$ as the basis.

b) Find the sum

$$\sum_{k=2}^{2026} k^2 + 2k + 5.$$

c) Using similar trick find the sums

$$\sum_{k=1}^n 5k^2 + 4k, \quad \sum_{k=1}^n k^3 + 2k^2.$$

Exercise 1.11. Let's start from some number $\binom{n}{k}$ inside the Pascal's triangle.

In one step we can go either in north-east or north-west direction.

Find the sum of all numbers we can reach.

Binomial or Taylor or MacLaurin expansion

Exercise 1.12. Write the Taylor expansion (binomial expansion) at $x = 0$ for

$$(1 + x)^n, \quad (x + y)^n.$$

Exercise 1.13. By plugging some special points to the $(x + y)^n$ or somewhere else find the sums

$$\binom{n}{0} + \binom{n}{1} + \binom{n}{2} + \cdots + \binom{n}{n}.$$

$$\sum_{k=0}^n k \binom{n}{k}, \quad \sum_{k=0}^n (k-1) \binom{n}{k}, \quad \sum_{k=0}^n (-1)^k \binom{n}{k}, \quad \sum_{k=0}^n (-1)^{k-1} k \binom{n}{k}$$

Hint: differentiation may help you.

How that can be?

Exercise 1.14. Be brave, really brave!

a) Take a deep breath!

b) Calculate

$$\binom{-1}{3}, \quad \binom{-5}{5}, \quad \binom{1.5}{3}, \quad \binom{-1/2}{4}, \quad \binom{1/3}{k}, \quad \binom{-1/2}{n}.$$

Exercise 1.15. a) Simplify

$$\binom{-1/2}{3} + \binom{-1/2}{4}.$$

b) Draw the Pascal's triangle (the whole half-plane!) starting from $\binom{-1/2}{0}$.

c) Draw the Pascal's triangle (the whole half-plane!) starting from $\binom{1/3}{0}$.

Exercise 1.16. Write the Taylor expansion at $x = 0$ for

$$\frac{1}{1-x}, \quad (1+x)^{-5}, \quad (1+x)^{-1/2}, \quad (1+3x)^{1/3}, \quad (1-5x)^{1/2}.$$

Exercise 1.17. Simplify

$$\binom{10}{0} \binom{-0.5}{7} + \binom{10}{1} \binom{-0.5}{6} + \binom{10}{2} \binom{-0.5}{5} + \cdots + \binom{10}{7} \binom{-0.5}{0}.$$

Hint: for a honest proof consider the binomial expansion of $(1+x)^1, (1+x)^{-0.5}, (1+x)^{10-0.5}$.

Exercise 1.18. Homage to Newton.

a) Write the Taylor expansion at $x = 0$ for $(1-x^2)^{1/2}$.

b) Visually (or analytically if you wish) find the integral

$$\int_{-1}^1 (1-x^2)^{1/2}.$$

c) Calculate the sums

$$\binom{1/2}{0} - \frac{1}{3} \binom{1/2}{1} + \frac{1}{5} \binom{1/2}{2} + \cdots$$
$$\sum_{k=2}^{\infty} \frac{1}{2k+1} \frac{(2k-3)!!}{(2k)!!}$$



Home assignment-1:

1. Simplify

$$\sum_{a+b+c=100} \binom{100}{a} \cdot \binom{100-a}{b}.$$

2. 1.9(2) in the old enumeration:

Find explicit formula for the sum

$$1^3 + 2^3 + \dots + n^3.$$

Hint: represent the general term k^3 as the sum of binomial coefficients and then use the hockey stick or Christmas stocking or boomerang!

3. [*] Using hockey stick decomposition find the sums

$$\sum_{k=1}^n 5k^2 + 4k.$$

4. [*] Take a deep breath and calculate

$$\binom{-1}{3}, \quad \binom{-5}{5}, \quad \binom{1.5}{3}, \quad \binom{-1/2}{4}, \quad \binom{1/3}{k}, \quad \binom{-1/2}{n}.$$

5. Write the Taylor expansion at $x = 0$ for

$$\frac{1}{1-x}, \quad (1+x)^{-5}, \quad (1+x)^{-1/2}, \quad (1+3x)^{1/3}, \quad (1-5x)^{1/2}.$$

6. Watch a Veritasium video «Newton changed the game», [Ver21].

<https://youtu.be/gMlf1ELvRzc?si=VASoVKQj3Pk-wstA>,



You are more than welcome to solve other exercises that we skipped. Starred exercises will be on the quiz next day.

2 Day 2. Stars, bars and Gauss summation trick

Day 2 welcome quiz!

1. Decompose the function $h(k) = 2k^2 + k$ using the binomial coefficient basis $\binom{k}{0}$, $\binom{k}{1}$ and $\binom{k}{2}$.
2. Let's play hockey! Find the sum

$$\sum_{k=2}^{1000} 3\binom{k}{0} - 2\binom{k}{1} + 3\binom{k}{2}.$$

Hint: do not forget to bring money back to the bank if you borrow!

3. Find the value

$$\binom{1/3}{2} + \binom{1/3}{3} + \binom{4/3}{2}.$$



Gauss summation trick

Exercise 2.1. Simplify

$$\begin{aligned} & 1 + 2 + 3 + \cdots + n; \\ & 1^2 + 2^2 + 3^2 + \cdots + n^2; \\ & \binom{n}{1} + 2\binom{n}{2} + 3\binom{n}{3} + \cdots + n\binom{n}{n}; \\ & \binom{n}{0} + 2\binom{n}{1} + 3\binom{n}{2} + \cdots + (n+1)\binom{n}{n}; \\ & \binom{n}{2} + 2\binom{n}{3} + 3\binom{n}{4} + \cdots + (n-1)\binom{n}{n}; \\ & \binom{n}{0} + 3\binom{n}{1} + 5\binom{n}{2} + \cdots + (2n+1)\binom{n}{n}; \\ & \binom{n}{0} - 2\binom{n}{1} + 3\binom{n}{2} - 4\binom{n}{3} + \cdots + (-1)^n(n+1)\binom{n}{n}; \\ & 3\binom{n}{1} + 7\binom{n}{2} + 11\binom{n}{3} + \cdots + (4n-1)\binom{n}{n}; \\ & \binom{n}{1} - 2\binom{n}{2} + 3\binom{n}{3} - 4\binom{n}{4} + \cdots + (-1)^n n\binom{n}{n}; \end{aligned}$$

Stars and bars

Exercise 2.2. There are 20 chairs in a row and 7 students. Each student needs one chair to sit down. We do care only about which chairs are occupied.

- a) In how many ways chairs can be occupied?
- b) In how many ways chairs can be occupied if there should be at least one empty chair between occupied chairs?
- c) In how many ways chairs can be occupied if there should be at least two empty chairs between occupied chairs?

Exercise 2.3. I have four bags of different colors and 20 identical marble stones.

- a) In how many different ways can I put marbles into bags?
- b) In how many different ways can I put marbles into bags if there should be no empty bags?

Theorem 2.1 (Stars and bars theorem). The number of ways to distribute n identical objects into k distinguishable bags is equal to

$$\binom{n+k-1}{n} = \binom{n+k-1}{k-1}.$$

Hint: n is the number of stars and $(k-1)$ is the number of bars.

Exercise 2.4. There are 5 types of post-cards sold at the post-office.

- a) In how many different ways can I buy 12 post-cards?
- b) In how many different ways can I buy 12 post-cards if I would like to buy at least one post-card of every type?

Exercise 2.5. Consider the equation $x_1 + x_2 + x_3 + x_4 = 2026$.

- a) How many solutions does it have if x_1, x_2, x_3 and x_4 are non-negative integers?
- b) How many solutions does it have if x_1, x_2, x_3 and x_4 are positive integers?
- c) How many solutions does it have if all x_i are integers and $x_i \geq 2$ for all i ?
- d) How many solutions does it have if all x_i are integers and $x_i \geq i$ for all i ?

Exercise 2.6. There are 10 standard indistinguishable dices.

- a) How many different combinations of scores are possible?
- b) How many different combinations of scores are possible if at least one dice shows 6?
- c) How many different combinations of scores are possible if no dice shows 5 nor 6?

Exercise 2.7. Stars, bars, circles and probability!

Consider a well shuffled deck of 52 cards. I open the cards one by one.

- a) How many cards on average I open to see the first Queen?
- b) How many cards on average I open to see the third Ace?
- c) What is expected number of cards between the third and the fourth King?
- d) What is the probability that the third Ace will be the 20-th card opened?
- e) Write combinatorial identities hidden in a), b) and c).

Visualize it

Exercise 2.8. a) Express as a binomial coefficient and visualize the sum:

$$1 + 2 + 3 + 4 + \cdots + n.$$

b) Visualize the Fuji-sum and simplify it!

$$1 + 2 + 3 + \cdots + (n - 1) + n + (n - 1) + \cdots + 3 + 2 + 1.$$

c) Recall the multiplication table for numbers from 1 to 10. Why the sum of all numbers is just

$$1^3 + 2^3 + 3^3 + \cdots + 10^3?$$

Simplify the sum!



Home assignment: day 2 → day 5

Deadline: 2026-07-03, 16:59.

1. There are 10 standard indistinguishable dices.
 - a) How many different combinations of scores are possible?
 - b) How many different combinations of scores are possible if at least one dice shows 6?
 - c) How many different combinations of scores are possible if no dice shows 5 nor 6?
2. There are 5 types of post-cards sold at the post-office.
 - a) In how many different ways can I buy 12 post-cards?
 - b) In how many different ways can I buy 12 post-cards if I would like to buy at least one post-card of every type?
3. Using Gauss summation trick or otherwise find the sum:

$$\binom{n}{0} - 2\binom{n}{1} + 3\binom{n}{2} - 4\binom{n}{3} \cdots + (-1)^n(n+1)\binom{n}{n};$$

4. Recall the mother-identity

$$(1+x)^n = 1 + \binom{n}{1}x^1 + \binom{n}{2}x^2 + \cdots + \binom{n}{n}x^n.$$

- (a) Find the first derivative of the mother-identity.
- (b) Find the value of the sum

$$\binom{n}{1} + 2 \cdot 7 \cdot \binom{n}{2} + 3 \cdot 7^2 \cdot \binom{n}{2} + \cdots + n \cdot 7^{n-1} \binom{n}{n}.$$

- (c) Find the second derivative of the mother-identity.
- (d) Find the value of the sum

$$2 \cdot 1 \binom{n}{2} + 3 \cdot 2 \cdot 9 \cdot \binom{n}{3} + 4 \cdot 3 \cdot 9^2 \cdot \binom{n}{4} + 5 \cdot 4 \cdot 9^3 \cdot \binom{n}{5} + \cdots + n(n-1)9^{n-2} \binom{n}{n}.$$

Demo for the quiz on day 3

1. Using Gauss summation trick or otherwise find the sum

$$3\binom{n}{1} + 5\binom{n}{2} + 7\binom{n}{3} + \cdots + (2n+1)\binom{n}{n}.$$

2. Consider the equation $a + b + c = 100$ with integers $a \geq 3, b \geq 2, c \geq 5$.
How many solutions are there?



3 Day 3. Recurrence relations

Exercise 3.1. Recurrence equations starter pack :)

a) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n = a_{n-1} + 3, \quad a_1 = 20.$$

b) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$b_n = 3 \cdot b_{n-1}, \quad b_1 = 20.$$

c) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$c_n = (n + 3) \cdot c_{n-1}, \quad c_1 = 20.$$

d) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$d_n = n + 3 + d_{n-1}, \quad d_1 = 20.$$

e) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$e_n = n^2 - 3n + 2 + e_{n-1}, \quad e_1 = 20.$$

f) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$f_n = (n^2 - 3n + 2)f_{n-1}, \quad f_1 = 20.$$

g) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$g_n = \frac{n+2}{n+1}g_{n-1}, \quad g_1 = 20.$$

h) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$h_n = \frac{1}{n^2 + n} + h_{n-1}, \quad h_1 = 20.$$

Exercise 3.2. Gauss trick with subtraction!

a) Find the sum

$$S = 2 + 2 \cdot (1/3) + 2 \cdot (1/3)^2 + 2 \cdot (1/3)^3 + \dots$$

b) Solve the recurrence equation

$$S_n = S_{n-1} + 3 \cdot (1/5)^n, \quad S_0 = 0.$$

c) Solve the recurrence equation

$$S_n = S_{n-1} + n \cdot (1/5)^n, \quad S_0 = 0.$$

Exercise 3.3. You draw n lines on a plane, they split the plane into some number of regions.

a) What is the minimal number of regions?

b) What is the maximal number of regions?

Idea 2. Consider the equation

$$x_t + \alpha_1 x_{t-1} + \alpha_2 x_{t-2} = \text{poly}(t).$$

The solution can be always represented as a sum or product of some geometric series and polynomials.

Exercise 3.4. Unique root case.

a) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 5a_{n-1} + 6a_{n-2} = 0, \quad a_0 = 3, a_1 = 5.$$

b) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 7a_{n-1} + 12a_{n-2} = 6, \quad a_0 = 1, a_1 = 12.$$

c) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 8a_{n-1} + 15a_{n-2} = 8n - 22, \quad a_0 = 5, a_1 = 22.$$

Exercise 3.5. We start with one pair of young rabbits $F_1 = 1$. It takes one period of time for a pair of rabbits to mature. Every mature pair of rabbits in one period of time will give birth to a new young pair of rabbits.

a) Find F_2, F_3, F_4, F_5 .

b) Deduce the recurrence relation for F_n .

c) Find the general formula for F_n .

d) Which term in the general formula can be ignored for the big n ?

e) Guess and prove formulas for

$$\sum_{k=0}^n F_k, \quad \sum_{k=0}^n F_{2k}, \quad \sum_{k=1}^n F_{2k-1}, \quad F_{n+1}F_{n-1} - F_n^2.$$

f) Which of the following formulas are valid?

$$F_{m+n} = F_m F_{n+1} + F_{m-1} F_n$$

$$F_n^2 + F_{n+1}^2 = F_{2n+1}$$

$$F_{n+1}^2 - F_{n-1}^2 = F_{2n}$$

$$\sum_{k=0}^n F_k^2 = F_n F_{n+1}.$$

Exercise 3.6. The mighty lag operator!

Let L be the lag operator and $\Delta = 1 - L$. Consider the sequences $x_n = 5^n$, $y_n = n \cdot 5^n$ and $z_n = 3^n$.

a) Find $(1 - 3L)x_n$, Δx_n , $(1 - 5L)x_n$.

b) Find $\Delta(1 - 3L)x_n$, $\Delta(1 - 5L)x_n$, $(1 - 5L)^2 x_n$.

c) Find $(1 - 3L)y_n$, Δy_n , $(1 - 5L)y_n$.

d) Find $\Delta(1 - 3L)y_n$, $\Delta(1 - 5L)y_n$, $(1 - 5L)^2 y_n$.

e) Find $(1 - 3L)(1 - 5L)x_n$ and $(1 - 3L)(1 - 5L)z_n$.

f) Rewrite the equation $a_t - 7a_{t-1} + 12a_{t-2} = 0$ using lag operator.

Warning! Remember that $(1 - 3L)$ or $(1 - 5L)$ is not a number! Lag operator is just a convenient notation to shift index!

Exercise 3.7. Double root case.

a) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 8a_{n-1} + 16a_{n-2} = 0, \quad a_0 = 3, a_1 = 0.$$

b) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 4a_{n-1} + 13a_{n-2} = 20, \quad a_0 = 6, a_1 = 4.$$

c) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$q_n - 6q_{n-1} + 9q_{n-2} = 8n - 20, \quad q_0 = 2, a_1 = 12.$$

Home assignment: day 3 → day 6

Deadline: 2026-07-06, 14:59.

1. Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n = (n + 1) + a_{n-1}, \quad a_1 = 100.$$

Hint: recall that $1 + 2 + 3 + 4 + \dots + n = \binom{n+1}{2} = \frac{n(n+1)}{2}$.

2. Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n + 5a_{n-1} + 6a_{n-2} = 0, \quad a_0 = 3, a_1 = 5.$$

3. Solve the recurrence equation:

$$c_n = 2 \cdot c_{n-1} + 3, \quad c_1 = 20.$$

4. Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 7a_{n-1} + 12a_{n-2} = 6, \quad a_0 = 1, a_1 = 12.$$

5. Watch a Veritasium video «This equation will change how you see the world», [Ver20].

<https://youtu.be/ovJcsL7vyrk?si=kh8wjM2e6dgLSXzj>.



Demo for the quiz on day 4

1. Solve the recurrence equation:

$$b_n = \frac{n+5}{n+4}b_{n-1}, \quad b_1 = 100.$$

2. Here L is the lag operator and $x_n = 6^n$. Find the values

$$(1 - 5L)x_n, \quad (1 - 6L)x_n, \quad (1 - 6L)(1 - 5L)x_n.$$

4 Day 4. More recurrence equations

Exercise 4.1. Double root case.

a) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 8a_{n-1} + 16a_{n-2} = 0, \quad a_0 = 3, a_1 = 0.$$

b) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 4a_{n-1} + 4a_{n-2} = 20, \quad a_0 = 20, a_1 = 21.$$

c) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$q_n - 6q_{n-1} + 9q_{n-2} = 8n - 20, \quad q_0 = 2, a_1 = 12.$$

Exercise 4.2. Unique complex root case.

a) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 4a_{n-1} + 13a_{n-2} = 0, \quad a_0 = 4, a_1 = 2.$$

b) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n - 4a_{n-1} + 13a_{n-2} = 20, \quad a_0 = 6, a_1 = 4.$$

c) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n + 9a_{n-2} = 10n - 8, \quad a_0 = 7, a_1 = 8.$$

Exercise 4.3. There are n passengers boarding an intercity bus and standing in queue. There are n places and each passenger has its own place on the ticket. The problem is that the first passenger in the queue is very nervous, he rushes in the bus and takes one place at random. Each next passenger takes his seat according to the ticket if the seat is free. And if his own seat is occupied each passenger takes a random free seat.

Let p_n be the probability that the last passenger in the queue will get his seat.

a) What is the initial conditions p_2 ?

b) Build the recurrence equation for p_n .

c) Guess the solution!

Exercise 4.4. I have 100 safes. Each safe can be closed without a key, but requires a specific unique key to be opened. I randomly distribute 100 keys into 100 safes, one key per safe. I leave 5 safes open and I close other safes. So I have access to 5 keys and I can use them to open other safes and inside these safes there are more keys...

Let's denote by p_{kn} the probability that I can open all n safes, given that in the beginning there are k safes open and $(n - k)$ safes closed.

a) What are the initial conditions p_{0n} and p_{nn} ?

b) Build the recurrence equation for p_{kn} .

c) Guess the solution!

Let's denote by e_{kn} the expected number of open safes, given that in the beginning there are k safes open and $(n - k)$ safes closed.

4. What are the initial conditions e_{0n} and e_{nn} ?

5. Build the recurrence equation for e_{kn} .

6. Guess the solution!

Exercise 4.5. I enter a casino in Monte Carlo with 50 tokens. I play the roulette. I always bet one token on black. I will leave the casino when my fortune will be 70 tokens or 0 tokens.

In a typical Monte Carlo roulette there are 18 black pockets, 18 red pockets and zero. Let p_n be the probability that I will leave the casino as winner if I have n tokens now.

a) What are the initial conditions p_0 and p_{70} ?

b) Build the recurrence equation for p_n .

c) Solve the recurrence equation and find p_{50} .

d) How the answers would change for Las Vegas roulette with zero and double zero pockets?

e) How the answers would change for an abstract fair casino with no zero nor double zero?

Let e_n be the expected number of spins before I leave the casino (as winner or as loser).

6. What are the initial conditions e_0 and e_{70} ?

7. Build the recurrence equation for e_n .

8. Solve the recurrence equation and find e_{50} .

9. How the answers would change for Las Vegas roulette with zero and double zero pockets?

10. How the answers would change for an abstract fair casino with no zero nor double zero?

Exercise 4.6. I have a broken light switch button in my room. The switch button should turn the light on if the light is off and vice versa. On the first press the button works with probability $1/2$, on the second press — with probability $1/3$, on the third one — with probability $1/4$ and so on. Initially my room is dark.

What is the probability that my room will be dark after I press the button 100 times?

Exercise 4.7. You play a the following lottery with the casino. There is a hat on the table. A fair dice is thrown until the game ends.

- If the dice shows one then you get +1 dollar immediately and the game continues.
- If the dice shows two then +2 dollars are added to the hat and the game continues.
- If the dice shows three then +3 dollars are added to the hat and the game continues.
- If the dice shows four then the sum in the hat goes back to casino and the game continues.
- If the dice shows five then the sum in the hat goes back to the casino and the game ends.
- If the dice shows six then the game ends and you receive the content of the hat.

Let e_n be your total expected payoff if there are n dollars in the hat now.

1. Build the recurrence equation for e_n .
2. Find the solution.
3. What is the price of one dollar in the hat in real dollars? What is the fair price to participate in this game?

Exercise 4.8. Now the systems!

a) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$\begin{cases} a_n = 3a_{n-1} + 2b_{n-1} - 4, \\ b_n = 2a_{n-1} + 3b_{n-1} - 4, \\ a_0 = 1, \quad b_0 = 0. \end{cases}$$

b) Solve the recurrence equation:

$$\begin{cases} a_n = 3a_{n-1} - 2b_{n-1} - 4, \\ b_n = -2a_{n-1} + 3b_{n-1} + 4, \\ a_0 = 1, \quad b_0 = 0. \end{cases}$$

Home assignment: day 4 → day 7

Deadline: 2026-07-07, 14:59.

1. Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n + 6a_{n-1} + 9a_{n-2} = 0, \quad a_0 = 5, a_1 = 10.$$

2. Solve the recurrence equation:

$$c_n + 6c_{n-1} + 10c_{n-2} = 0, \quad c_0 = 0, c_1 = 10.$$

3. Solve the recurrence equation:

$$a_n = (n + 5)a_{n-1}, \quad a_1 = 100.$$

You may certainly use factorial in your answer!

4. I enter a casino in Las Vegas with 50 tokens. I play the roulette. I always bet one token on black. I will leave the casino when my fortune will be 70 tokens or 0 tokens.

In a typical Las Vegas roulette there are 38 pockets: 18 black pockets, 18 red pockets, one zero and one double zero. Let p_n be the probability that I will leave the casino as winner if I have n tokens now.

- What are the initial conditions p_0 and p_{70} ?
- Build the recurrence equation for p_n .
- Solve the recurrence equation for p_n .
- Evaluate p_{50} up to 2 digits.

Demo for the quiz on day 5

- Consider the recurrence equation $y_n - 7y_{n-1} + 10y_{n-2} = 0$.
Find all solutions of the form $y_n = \lambda^n$.
- You know that $r_n = c \cdot 2^n + d \cdot n \cdot 2^n + 4$ is the solution of some recurrence equation with initial conditions $r_0 = 6$ and $r_1 = 10$.
Find c and d .

5 Day 5. Binomial coefficients and recurrence relations recap

6 Yet to discover

Inclusions and exclusions

Proofs to DIE for

Wandermonde's identity

Exercise 6.1. Simplify

$$\binom{a}{0} \binom{b}{m} + \binom{a}{1} \binom{b}{m-1} + \binom{a}{2} \binom{b}{m-2} + \cdots + \binom{a}{m} \binom{b}{0}.$$

$$\binom{a}{0} \binom{m}{0} + \binom{a}{1} \binom{m}{1} + \binom{a}{2} \binom{m}{2} + \cdots + \binom{a}{m} \binom{m}{m}.$$

$$\binom{a}{0}^2 + \binom{a}{1}^2 + \binom{a}{2}^2 + \cdots + \binom{a}{a}^2.$$

Exercise 6.2. There are $n = 500$ fishes in the pond, $t = 30$ of them are tagged. You capture $c = 5$ fishes at random without replacement. Let the random variable Y be the number of captured tagged fishes. Find the probabilities $\mathbb{P}(Y = 0)$, $\mathbb{P}(Y = 1)$, $\mathbb{P}(Y = 2)$, $\mathbb{P}(Y = y)$.

Exercise 6.3. There are $n = 24$ candies in the jar, 14 with orange flavour and 10 with ananas flavour. You take 6 candies at random. Let Y be the number of candies with orange flavour you picked. Find the probabilities $\mathbb{P}(Y = 0)$, $\mathbb{P}(Y = 1)$, $\mathbb{P}(Y = 2)$, $\mathbb{P}(Y = y)$.

Exercise 6.4. A bridge hand (random 13 cards out of 52-card standard deck) is dealt.

- a) What is the probability that the hand contains no spades?
- b) What is the probability that the hand contains exactly 5 hearts?
- c) What is the probability that the hand contains at most two aces?

Exercise 6.5. Vandermonde-like identities in a funny notation. Here I intentionally omit the running index i , I write the first summation term and specify with $\uparrow$ and $\downarrow$ which terms goes up or down in the sum.

- a) Simplify and rewrite in a standard notation

$$\sum \binom{n}{0\uparrow} \binom{n\downarrow}{k}.$$

- b) Simplify and rewrite in a standard notation

$$\sum \binom{a\uparrow}{a} \binom{n\downarrow}{k}.$$

- c) Simplify and rewrite in a standard notation

$$\sum \binom{b}{0\uparrow} \binom{n}{k\downarrow}.$$

Exercise 6.6. Simplify

$$\sum_{a+b+c=k} \binom{n_1}{a} \binom{n_2}{b} \binom{n_3}{c}.$$

Sources of Wisdom

- [Ver21] Veritasium. Newton changed the game. 2021. URL: <https://youtu.be/gMlf1ELvRzc?si=VASoVKQj3Pk-wstA>. How Newton discovered binomial coefficients for non-integer values and used them to calculate pi, 19 minutes.
- [Ver20] Veritasium. This equation will change how you see the world. 2020. URL: <https://youtu.be/ovJcsL7vyrk?si=kh8wjM2e6dgLSXzj>. How chaos may arise from a simple recurrence equation, 19 minutes.
- [Gra94] Ronald L Graham. Concrete mathematics: a foundation for computer science. Pearson Education India, 1994. A classic captivating (really funny sometimes!) treatise on combinatorics from masters, 690 pages.
- [Har+10] John J Harris et al. Combinatorics and graph theory. Springer-Verlag New York, 2010. Accessible book with a lot of pictures, stories and nice explanations, 355 pages.
- [Gui25] David Guichard. An Introduction to Combinatorics and Graph Theory. 2025. URL: https://www.whitman.edu/mathematics/cgt_online/cgt.pdf. Short open access introductory book with pictures and good intuition, 155 pages.

